

Homework #4: Microaggressions and Microaffirmations

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Scenario 1.

Riley is a software engineer who does maintenance (bug fixing) on a large system. Riley is visually impaired. Robert says to Riley: *“That’s pretty good stuff you’re doing. I didn’t expect anyone with your disability could understand the code base – and you did it so quickly. I’m impressed.”*

(a) How might Robert’s statement make someone with a visual disability feel?5 pts

Robert’s statement is very backhanded to someone with a visual impairment. Saying Riley is doing good work even though Riley has a disability makes it seem like people with visual impairments are not able to understand code bases as well as people without that impairment. This reaffirms a harmful stereotype that people with visual impairments are incapable of understanding complex systems. This might make Riley feel underestimated and patronized by Robert because instead of Robert complimenting Riley’s skill as a software engineer and quick thinker, Robert bases the skill solely off of Riley’s visual impairment, which could make it seem like if Riley did not have a visual impairment, Riley would not be considered skilled, which is an incorrect statement because Riley’s skill is based off of Riley’s hard work and talent.

(b) How could you rephrase Robert’s statement as a microaffirmation? Explain why you think your response would be better5 pts

Removing the second sentence from Robert’s statement *“I didn’t expect anyone with your disability could understand the code base – and you did it so quickly”* is necessary to remove the microaggression against Riley’s visual impairment. Instead, saying something like *“That’s pretty good stuff you’re doing. Your quick understanding of the codebase is very impressive”* would be a good microaffirmation. In this statement, only Riley’s skill and impressive work with debugging the code base are mentioned. It acknowledges Riley’s expertise and contributions without implying that Riley’s success is unexpected. By doing so, this microaffirmation fosters an inclusive and respectful work environment where only merit is commented on without bringing any personal features into the workplace to differentiate/target anyone.

Scenario 2.

Your colleague Ari is openly a member of the LGBT community and is generally respected and well liked in the office. However, occasionally, when Ari walks by, a co-worker named Sam gives them a light tap on the shoulder and makes casual comments like “Looking sharp today,” with a friendly smile. But when Sam thinks Ari isn’t looking, he subtly winks and smirks at other workers nearby, as if to imply something else. You notice that Ari seems to be aware of the gestures and remarks, and they appear uncomfortable but do not speak up.

In terms of the 4D framework for bystander intervention, identify the steps you might take to address this situation5 pts

Using the 4D framework, I would start with a “delay” approach of intervention. I would first ask Ari privately how Ari feels about Sam’s interactions. I would ensure Ari knows that I see the behavior of Sam as being inappropriate and would ask Ari for the best course of action before taking a delegated or direct approach to stopping the behavior. If Ari decides a delegated approach is better, I would speak with other co-workers and see if they would support me in speaking to Sam in a professional matter to make Sam aware of his behavior that makes another co-worker uncomfortable. If Ari is hesitant to bring in other co-workers, I would take a direct approach. The next time Sam makes a remark I would say something like “*Sam, let’s keep compliments professional so everyone at work feels comfortable and does not have to feel ostracized by others.*” Taking a direct approach like this ensures that Ari’s name does not have to come up to call out Sam on bad behavior, and Sam is told he is making co-workers uncomfortable in a public setting so other co-workers also know that Sam’s behavior should not be encouraged.

Scenario 3.

Your team is visiting an important client at their site. Melody, one of your teammates who is Asian-American, doesn't understand something that the client asked. It's a simple mistake that anyone could make, but because of the misunderstanding, Melody's answer doesn't quite fit the client's question. The client looks upset and says sharply: *"I want to speak to someone who understands English."*

You know Melody grew up in a suburb of New York City, and you know she speaks perfectly clear English. In the face of the client's outrage, Melody stays quiet and doesn't say anything. But you can see that she's upset and angry.

(a) How do you expect Melody might feel about this situation?.....5 pts

Melody is an Asian American and had clearly spoken native English being from New York City. The client, knowing that Melody is from America after speaking to her, still passes a remark claiming that she does not understand English is a clear attack on Melody's ethnicity. Melody may feel attacked based on her ethnicity because of that and would feel extremely uncomfortable if the client was ethnically profiling her. In addition, Melody is likely to feel embarrassed and humiliated by the client's remark. Melody is clearly qualified to be on the team, but just from one misunderstanding, her position on the team is undermined and she is falsely called out as incompetent in front of her teammates.

(b) You see that the manager leading your team smiles reassuringly at the client and asks another person on your team to answer. In terms of the 4Ds, what are some steps you could or should do?5 pts

In this situation, the manager is leading the team. The manager's responsibility is to ensure that all team members are being treated in a professional manner. Therefore, in terms of the 4Ds, it is probably best to take the direct approach or a delegated approach as well as a delayed approach after the meeting. For the direct approach, it is necessary for the person asked to answer or another teammate to speak out and inform everyone that *"Melody simply misunderstood the question as we did. She can answer the question."* By saying something like this, Melody is given another chance to respond, and comradery is shown to the client that everyone on the team supports each other. With the delegated approach, I would bring up the situation to other teammates so they can share their thoughts on the client's behavior and the manager's response. Lastly, I would use the "delay" approach to address the situation with the manager with the other team members so the manager knows that it is not right to put down a team member to appease the client's behavior.

(c) Instead of the situation in (b), suppose you are the manager of the team. In terms of the 4D framework for bystander intervention, what are some steps you could or should do? If they're the same as in (b), why? If they're different, why?5 pts

If I were the manager, I would implement the direct approach and also do a delayed approach to address the situation. With the direct approach, I would call out the client in an effective manner by saying *"Melody is an extremely qualified member of our team. She misunderstood your question as we all can do from time to time. She can answer your question."* This supports Melody in front of the client and slightly reprimands the client for being rude while being respectful and assertive with the tone. After the meeting, I would speak with Melody separately and ensure that she knows she is a valuable member of the team and that if she would like, she can give a complaint to the manager of the client for ethnically profiling her in the meeting.

Scenario 4.

You're in a meeting with another team discussing a technical project. Sarah, a female software engineer, suggests a solution to a coding issue, but her input is ignored by the group repeatedly. A few minutes later, a male colleague, Mark, makes the same suggestion, and the team reacts positively, discussing it as if it were a new idea. After the meeting, the other team's manager approaches Sarah and says: "Wasn't that your idea too? *I'm surprised you came up with that before Mark!*"

(a) How might the statement make Sarah feel?.....5 pts

Sarah might feel frustrated, undervalued, and dismissed because of her gender. The manager's comment, while acknowledging that she had the idea first, also implies that typically she is not capable of coming up with a good idea before Mark. This suggests an unconscious bias that undermines her expertise as a software engineer. She is as qualified as her coworkers and should not be thought of as below or less intelligent because of her gender. The stereotype that males are more capable and intelligent than females is blatantly incorrect and shows that the manager and the group are underlyingly misogynistic while in reality Sarah is as intelligent and capable as them. Additionally, because her idea was initially ignored but later accepted when repeated by a male colleague, she may feel invisible or overlooked because of her gender. It is not just for her to be ignored when male colleagues are not and the sense of unjust conduct in the workplace that Sarah must feel is unfair and unprofessional.

(b) How could you rephrase the statement as a microaffirmation instead? Explain why you think your response would be better5 pts

A better way to phrase the statement would be: "*Sarah, Mark suggested your idea when the credit and consideration should have gone to you for suggesting it first. I apologize for ignoring your input and I will ensure to speak up early and make the others aware of this bias so that this does not happen again. Please let me know what I can do to ensure you are treated as you should be by not just me but everyone on the team.*" This response directly recognizes Sarah's contribution without expressing surprise at her ability. It also admits the manager's ignorance in the meeting and acknowledges the mistake the manager and team made by not treating Sarah equally. It also shows Sarah that the manager does not condone unequal treatment and will make the necessary changes to ensure equality in the workplace.

(c) Would your answer to (a) be different if Sarah were male? If yes, explain why. If no, describe the commonality in the microaggressive statement (i.e., how the two situations are similar) – that is, describe the nuance in how the statement might be interpreted5 pts

Yes, the response might be slightly different because in (a) I assume that Sarah would feel unjustly treated because the team undermines her competence because of her gender. For a male, I would not assume that the team undermines competence because of gender and would link the cause to something else such as an ethnical or background difference. This is because the coworkers listened to Mark over Sarah, indicating that they would listen to a male over a female. If Sarah were male, the coworkers would only listen to Mark for another reason because Mark is also male, so gender would not be a differentiating factor here. It is also true that there are less stereotypes for males in the workplace because many workplaces are still male-dominated, so females are treated differently because of implicit biases males have when a female is present in the workplace. I do believe that if the same case were true for a male, there would still be a microaggression, but it would likely be due to another factor and my response to (a) would single out that factor as the cause of unjust treatment.

Generative AI: This was written using Generative AI as an idea formulation tool.